

Technical Overview & Operations Guide

Everything built as of 4 Aug 2026: the repos, how the pieces fit together, how to operate it, and how to administer access.

1 · The repositories and how they relate

REPO	ROLE	URL IT SERVES
daf-cgoc-2025/penpal	Penpal DEV — where all changes land and get tested first. Currently hosts the full live signup page.	daf-cgoc-2025.github.io/penpal/
dafcgcg-penpal/penpal	Penpal PROD — the public home. Still shows the "coming soon" placeholder; receives the dev code once stakeholders approve launch.	penpal.dafcgcg.org
daf-cgoc-2025/nationalcgoc.github.io	Main site DEV — staging for dafcgcg.org. Analytics upgrade waiting in PR #48.	—
nationalcgoc/nationalcgoc.github.io	Main site PROD — the live council site. Updated via cross-fork pull request from dev.	dafcgcg.org

Flow for any change: edit → push to the **dev** repo → verify on the dev URL → copy/PR the same change to **prod**. The penpal page's original prototype also lives on branch `feature/penpal-mentorship-mvp` of the main-site repo; it is kept for history but deliberately never merged — the standalone penpal repos are the page's home now.

2 · How the system works



- **No servers, no cost.** Static pages on GitHub Pages; Firebase free tier (a signup uses ~0.02% of the daily free quota); Apps Script and the Sheet run on the free consumer Google account.
- **Security lives in the Firestore rules** (`firestore.rules` in the penpal repo — already published): the public form may only *create* correctly-shaped submissions; all reads require an approved signed-in dashboard user. Verified end-to-end 4 Aug 2026.

- **If Firebase is ever unreachable**, the form falls back to opening the visitor's email app addressed to `nationalcgoc@gmail.com` — no submission is silently lost.
- **Website analytics**: every page carries both GA tags, so data appears in the existing GA property *and* the Firebase console. File downloads, outbound clicks, and scroll depth come from GA4 "Enhanced measurement" (a property setting, on by default). Weekly and monthly summary emails are generated by `ga4-reports.gs`.

3 · Setup — what's done, what remains

Done and verified: penpal dev site live with the full page · Firestore database created · security rules published · live test submission succeeded end-to-end · admin dashboard built and deployed · main-site analytics staged in PR #48.

REMAINING STEP	WHO	HOW
Apps Script (Sheet + email + reports)	Whoever holds the nationalcgoc@gmail.com login (Hugh)	Follow README-FIRST.pdf in the <code>penpal-backend-kit.zip</code> — 10 minutes, one <code>setup</code> run creates all schedules.
Enable dashboard sign-in	Anyone with Firebase console access (Enrique)	Firebase console → DAFCGOC → Authentication → Get started → Sign-in method → Google → Enable → Save ; then Settings → Authorized domains → Add <code>daf-cgoc-2025.github.io</code> (and later <code>penpal.dafcgoc.org</code>).
Merge main-site analytics	Oti / Hugh	Merge PR #48 on the dev main-site repo, then carry to prod as usual.
Launch penpal to prod	Oti + stakeholders	Push the dev repo's code to <code>dafcgoc-penpal/penpal</code> ; remove the <code>noindex</code> meta in <code>index.html</code> ; delete the demo data (below).

4 · How to check the data

WHAT	WHERE
Submissions — friendly view	Dashboard: <code>daf-cgoc-2025.github.io/penpal/admin/</code> → sign in → Responses tab (search, filter, click a row for full detail).
Submissions — spreadsheet	Google Sheet "Penpal Intakes" in <code>nationalcgoc@gmail.com</code> 's Drive (after Hugh's setup); new rows + an email within 15 minutes of each signup.
Submissions — raw database	Firebase console → DAFCGOC → Firestore Database → <code>penpalIntake</code> .
Program analytics	Dashboard Overview tab: signups over time, mentee/mentor split, sources, AFSCs, bases, goals, mentor strengths.
Website traffic	Firebase console → Analytics, or <code>analytics.google.com</code> ; plus the automatic weekly (Mon) and monthly (1st) report emails.
Board-ready PDF	Dashboard → Download report (PDF) — branded report with stats, charts, and the response table.

5 · Administering the dashboard

- **Super-admins (permanent, set in the security rules):** `arkady232@gmail.com` and `nationalcgoc@gmail.com`. They see everything and manage the viewer list.

- **Adding a viewer:** sign in as a super-admin → **Viewers** tab → enter their Gmail/Google-account email → choose scope → Add. Takes effect on their next sign-in.
- **Scopes:** *Responses + analytics* (full view) · *Responses only* · *Analytics only* — analytics-only viewers see aggregate charts but can never read names, emails, or any raw submission (enforced server-side).
- **Removing a viewer:** Viewers tab → Remove. Immediate.
- **Changing the permanent super-admin list** requires editing `firestore.rules` and re-publishing — ask the webmaster.

6 • Making changes safely

- **Page copy / sections:** edit `index.html` in the penpal dev repo, push, check the dev URL, then promote to prod.
- **Form fields:** three places must stay in sync — the field in `index.html`, `buildPayload()` in `js/penpal.js`, and the matching validation line in `firestore.rules` (re-publish rules after). Optionally map a new column in the poller script.
- **Analytics tags:** every page must carry `G-74QCBZFWWH` + `G-WT36BHRC7X`. Never re-introduce the retired `G-9MLXG6SFE1`.
- **Full technical docs** live in the penpal repo: `README.md` (architecture) and `SETUP.md` (console steps).

7 • Housekeeping flags

Temporary items to remove at launch: ① Ten demo submissions (`demo-00...09`, "Sample" family, @example.com emails) seeded for dashboard testing — delete from Firestore. ② The testing BCC to arkady232@gmail.com in both Apps Script files (`TEST_BCC` / `REPORT_BCC` → `''`). ③ The `noindex` meta tag on the penpal page once approved for search.

PII handling: submissions contain names, emails, and duty stations of military members. Keep dashboard viewer access, the Sheet, and the Firebase console limited to named council members; treat exported PDFs as official-use documents. The public site can never read this data back.